

GEORGIA OWNER-BUILDER PERMIT KIT

Qualify for the exemption · File the permit · Pass the inspections

Project Address: _____

County: _____

Owner-Builder: _____

Permit Application Date: _____

Every Georgia statute, rule, and requirement in this kit is cited on the
page it appears on — verified August 2026.

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First Edition — 2026

How to Use This Kit

Five working documents that take a Georgia owner-builder from "am I allowed to do this?" to a certificate of occupancy.

Georgia is one of the friendlier states to build your own home in — and one of the strangest to permit in. The eight state minimum codes bind you statewide whether or not anyone enforces them (§ 8-2-25(a)), but **permits and inspections are a local option** (§ 8-2-26(a)(4)) — some counties run full permit portals, and some have no building department at all. This kit separates the two: what the State fixes, cited here, and what your jurisdiction decides, which you fill in.

Georgia headline facts (each developed, with its full cite, in GA.1-GA.3)

The fact	Authority
The owner exemption is real and cost-unlimited — own land, own occupancy, not for sale or lease. But one sale of a self-built structure within 24 months (measured from that structure's CO) poisons the exemption for the next build.	§ 43-41-17(h)
Contractor licensing attaches over \$2,500 of work — among the lowest thresholds in the country. It governs the people you hire, not you.	§ 43-41-2(9)
Effective January 1, 2026 : 2024 I-Codes with 2026 Georgia Amendments and the 2023 NEC ; energy stays the 2015 IECC with Georgia amendments. Two tests are mandatory — blower door under 5 ACH50 , duct leakage at or under 6 cfm25/100 sq ft — by a certified DET verifier.	DCA; GA IECC R402.4.1.2, R403.3.3
On a septic lot, no physical development may begin until the County Health Department issues the septic construction permit.	DPH Rule 511-3-1-.03(2)

WHAT IS IN THE KIT

The five documents

	Document	What it does for you
GA.1	Owner-Builder Exemption Walkthrough	Whether you qualify, the 24-month rule, doing your own trade work, and what takes the exemption away. Read this first.
GA.2	Permit Application Checklist	What to gather and verify before you file — the code stack, septic and well, erosion control, driveway, Notice of Commencement, energy tests.
GA.3	Inspection Sequence	The inspection ladder for a Georgia dwelling, the energy-test gates, and fields for dates and results.
GA.4	Where to File Directory	Your county's offices and portals, the state agencies, and how to find each one.
GA.5	Forms & Documents Index	Each document you will meet: what it is, when, and from where.

HOW TO USE IT

- **Start with GA.1.** If you do not qualify — or you sold a self-built house in the last 24 months — nothing else matters yet.
- **Settle jurisdiction first** (GA.4): whether your parcel is inside a city, and whether your county enforces permits at all.
- **Work GA.2 with a pen** and do not file until the boxes are checked. On a septic lot, the health-department permit comes before you touch the ground.
- **Keep GA.3 on the job** and record every inspection date and result as it happens — especially the two DET test reports.

How these facts were checked — and what this is not

Every Georgia claim here was read against its primary source in August 2026 and is cited where it appears; where counties differ the kit says so. One honest caveat: O.C.G.A. text was read at a mirror current through March 28, 2024. The 2024–2025 session laws (SB 503, HB 635, SB 125) postdate it; none is reported to change the exemption text this kit quotes, but confirm anything you rely on at the official code. This is a process reference, not legal advice.